

“Biggest challenge for fertiliser sector is raw materials”

Arun Alagappan, Executive Chairman, Coromandel International, on why he sees opportunity in the fertiliser industry, despite import dependence

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As a fourth-generation member of the family that owns the 125-year-old Murugappa Group, Arun Alagappan has a proud legacy. For a good part of his career, he worked with group companies Tube Products of India and Cholamandalam Investment and Finance Company before moving to Coromandel International—an agri-solutions provider—a little over five years ago.

“I did not expect it (agriculture) to be so interesting,” he says, before offering a glimpse into how agriculture is changing—be it the new generation

taking charge or farmers using technologies such as drones in a big way.

This presents challenges as well as opportunities. For Alagappan, the answer lies in innovation by working closely with farmers and backward integration, with a presence in the four key areas of nutrients, crop protection, retail and tech solutions. In an interview with BT, he outlines his company’s strategy and how he is dealing with the conflict in West Asia that has created a fear of fertiliser shortages in the country just ahead of the sowing season.

Edited excerpts:

“We moved with more focus on backward integration and bought a mine in Senegal, which makes most of our rock phosphate, a key raw material for phosphoric acid”